fourth evening come a little earlier, and had we grabbed more of the chances that came our way, we might have made history. Despite missing out on a series win, we still had reason to be happy and were looking forward to the tour of Pakistan that was just round the corner.

India in Pakistan, March–April 2004

There was a lot of excitement about our tour to Pakistan. Playing Pakistan is always a big occasion for an Indian cricketer, and this was the first time we had played them in Pakistan since my debut series in 1989. The tour also seemed to have come at the best possible time for India; we had done well in the series Down Under and most of the players were in good form.

As soon as we landed in Pakistan we realized just how different this tour would be. Unlike the first time, when I was just sixteen, in 2004 I understood the full significance of an India–Pakistan series. The security was simply unbelievable. We were whisked through immigration and on our way to the hotel we had a security vehicle ahead of the team bus. There were also bikes escorting the bus and we even had a chopper flying above us. In the hotel we were received warmly and given instructions about the security protocols we were expected to follow. We were informed that the first room on our floor was to be occupied by security personnel, who would check every visitor who came to the floor. The floors above and below us had been sealed off. I had not experienced security like that before and it was a very strange feeling, because we were just sportsmen who had come to Pakistan to play cricket.

Leaving the hotel wasn’t an option and this meant the players spent a lot of time in each other’s rooms having dinner, playing cards and watching movies. It was always fun to be able to spend time together and the spirit of the team was excellent as we prepared for the first one-day international in Karachi on 13 March 2004.

It was the best possible start to the series, with the match decided on the very last ball. After we had scored 349 batting first, Pakistan responded well but came up short, with 344 in their fifty overs. Unfortunately, we lost the next two matches, but we did well to come back with victories in the final two games, winning the series 3–2. The final match was a thriller and we beat Pakistan by 40 runs in the end. I